URGE FIELD GUIDE / FOUNDER TOOLKIT

The Rejection Playbook

A practical guide to making the ask, handling the answer, and learning what to do next.

You cannot control the answer. You can control whether you ask, what you learn, and what you do next.

ASK. LEARN. ADJUST. REPEAT.

Rejection is part of building something. The aim isn't to become unaffected by it. The aim is to have a simple way to respond so one difficult moment doesn't decide what happens next.

1. Before you ask

Make the ask easier to act on before you send the message, make the call, or start the conversation.

Set an input goal

Choose a target you can control: for example, make five thoughtful asks this week. Count the asks, not just the yeses. Keep the target realistic and make sure each ask is appropriate for the person and situation.

Name the risk

Ask yourself: **“If they say no, what will actually happen?”** Write one honest sentence. Don't dismiss real risks, but separate likely consequences from imagined ones.

Decide your next step in advance

Before you ask, decide what you will do for each likely outcome: yes, no, or no response. That way, you don't have to invent a plan while you're disappointed.

My next ask: _____

If the answer is no, I will: _____

2. When you get an answer

A no, a delay, and silence are not the same thing. Respond to what you know—not to what you fear it means.

IF...	TRY...
They say no	Thank them. If it feels appropriate, ask one useful question: “Is there anything that would have made this a better fit?” Accept their answer and respect the boundary.
They don't reply	Wait a reasonable amount of time, then send one short follow-up if appropriate. If there is still no reply, move on rather than repeatedly chasing.
They raise an objection	Clarify what is behind it. Is it price, timing, trust, need, or something else? Use the answer to decide whether to adjust, follow up later, or stop.
You feel stung	Pause before replying. Take a short walk, get some water, or give yourself time. You can respond later when you know what you want to say.

Useful short replies

After a no: “Thanks for letting me know. I appreciate the clear answer.”

When feedback is welcome: “Could I ask what would have made this a better fit?”

After no response: “Just following up in case this got buried. No worries if it isn't a fit.”

When you need time: “Thanks for being honest. Let me think about that and get back to you.”

3. After the moment

Don't force yourself to feel fine. Give yourself a little space, then decide what—if anything—the experience tells you.

Take a reset

If the answer hits hard, step away briefly. Breathe, stretch, walk, or do something that helps you settle. You don't need to reply or make a big decision immediately.

Log the useful facts

Keep a simple record. It helps you notice patterns instead of treating every answer as a verdict on you or your idea.

DATE	WHAT I ASKED	OUTCOME	WHAT I LEARNED / NEXT STEP
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Separate the signal from the noise

After several asks, look for patterns:

- **The same concern keeps coming up:** consider changing the offer, message, price, or audience.
- **Different reasons each time:** there may be no clear pattern yet. Keep learning before making a big change.
- **It's about timing or fit:** note it and decide whether a respectful follow-up later makes sense.
- **You keep hearing nothing:** check whether the ask is clear, reaching the right person, and easy to answer.

> **A no is one data point—not a verdict on you. Look for patterns before deciding what it means.**

4. Build a simple routine

DAILY	WEEKLY
■ Make one appropriate ask or follow-up.	■ Review the asks and responses.
■ Record one thing you learned.	■ Look for one repeated pattern.
■ Choose a next step, even if that step is to stop pursuing this lead.	■ Choose one change to test next week.

5. A few reminders worth keeping

Measure what you can control: the quality of the ask, the number of thoughtful attempts, and what you learn.

Silence is not always a no. Follow up once when appropriate, then use your judgement and move on.

A no is information, not an identity. It may tell you about fit, timing, budget, priorities, or your offer. It does not define your worth.

Don't turn every no into a debate. Ask for feedback only when it is welcome, and respect the other person's answer.

More asks are not always better. Aim for thoughtful, relevant asks. Change your approach when the evidence calls for it.

You can stop. If the opportunity is wrong, the boundary is clear, or the cost is too high, stopping is a valid decision.

My rejection routine

Before I ask, I will…

_____

When I hear no or get no response, I will…

_____

After a difficult answer, I will…

_____

Each week, I will review…

_____

THE ROUTINE

Ask. Learn. Adjust. Repeat.

The aim isn't to avoid rejection. It's to respond to it thoughtfully, learn what the evidence supports, and keep choosing your next move.